PROJECT REPORT · 2026

Why we *buy now.*

How social media rewired the way consumers decide what to spend on — a study with case work on Starbucks, Nike, Daniel Wellington & Blue Tokai.

INDERPREET SINGH · AUTHOR • GUIDE: **JAYA RATHORE** • 024MBA111968

01 • THE SHIFT

The decision moved *online.*

Four eras of marketing in fifty years. Each one moved the moment of decision closer to the buyer — and further from the brand's own voice.

1970s – 1990s

Broadcast

TV · Print
Radio · Outdoor

Brand → audience. One-way. The buyer listened, then walked to a shelf to decide.

2000s – 2010s

Search

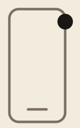
Google · Amazon
Email · Reviews

Audience finds brand. Buyers go looking. The first online reviews start mattering.

2010s – 2020s

Mobile

Apps · Notifications
Always-on access

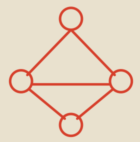


Always within reach. Convenience wins. Discovery becomes constant background noise.

2020s +

Social

Reels · Reviews
Influencers · UGC



Audience IS the brand. Buyers research peers before they research products. Trust got redistributed from advertising to people.

Two journeys, same buyer.

The same decision, made in completely different worlds.

THEN — PRE-2010

- See a TV / print ad

↓

- Ask a friend or family

↓

- Walk into a store

↓

- Decide at the shelf

↓

- Buy

NOW — SOCIAL-LED

- Scroll a feed, see a reel

↓

- Check reviews & ratings

↓

- Watch an influencer use it

↓

- Decide before the shop

↓

- Buy — then post about it

Six questions worth answering.

The study is built around six tight objectives — each one a specific thing to measure.

01

Measure social media's actual impact on what people buy.

02

Identify the levers — influencers, ads, reviews — that move buyers.

03

Compare platforms — which ones shape preference, and how.

04

Test the link between engagement on social and purchase intent.

05

Profile age effects — especially Gen Z and young professionals.

06

Translate findings into things brands can actually do.

Mixed method, kept simple.

A structured questionnaire on Google Forms gathered the primary signal. Secondary sources framed it.

DESIGN

Descriptive — describe what is happening — combined with light analytical work to find which levers matter most.

TOOLS

Percentage analysis, frequency tables, and basic visual charts. Kept lightweight on purpose; the survey size doesn't justify regression.

OBSERVATION

Alongside the survey, consumer behaviour was observed directly on platform — how people engaged with ads, influencer content, and promos in the wild.

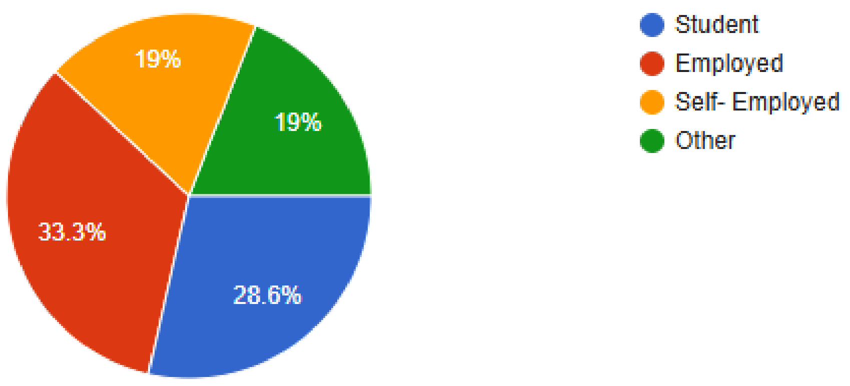
SCOPE

Instagram, YouTube, Facebook, Snapchat — the platforms the sample actually uses every day.

Not just students.

A mix worth noting — most of the sample earns its own money, full-time or running its own thing.

PRIMARY SURVEY · N=21



71%

EARN THEIR OWN INCOME

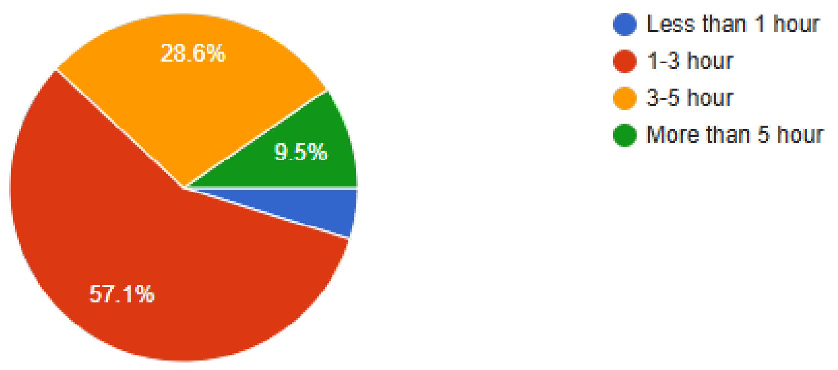
Employed *33.3%*, students *28.6%*, self-employed *19%*, other *19%*. The sample isn't all students — a clear majority have buying power.

So what. The percentages downstream aren't "what young people think" — they're what a working / earning sample reports about their actual purchases.

1–3 hours, every day.

A meaningful slice of the day — long enough to absorb several feeds, short enough that brands have to earn the attention.

PRIMARY SURVEY · N=21



57.1%

SPEND 1–3 HOURS A DAY

Plus *28.6%* at 3–5 hours and *9.5%* over 5 hours. Roughly *95%* of the sample spends at least an hour a day inside a social feed.

So what. Reach isn't the question. The question is what shows up during that 1–3 hour window — and how often the same brand does.

Two platforms run the show.

Instagram + YouTube reach almost the whole sample. Snapchat reaches most. Facebook reaches a few. Twitter is functionally absent — a single respondent.

So what. If a brand can only show up well in one place, that place is Instagram. If it can fund a second, that's YouTube. Anything left after that is bonus reach.

Ads are *unavoidable.*

85%

RESPONDENTS WHO SEE PRODUCT ADS OFTEN OR ALWAYS

52.4% say *often*. 33.3% say *always*. Almost no one says rarely.

The feed is a billboard now. The question isn't whether your audience sees ads — it's whether they see *yours*.

FOR THE BRAND

Constant exposure raises the bar. Generic, polished ads disappear. Specific, weird, or useful ones get remembered.

FOR THE BUYER

Discovery has become passive. Most new products are found while scrolling, not while searching.

THE MECHANIC

Targeting algorithms decide which ads each person sees. Two people open the same app and see different worlds.

Exposure becomes *spending.*

76.2%

HAVE BOUGHT A PRODUCT AFTER SEEING IT ON SOCIAL MEDIA

Three in four respondents converted from a feed at least once. Social media doesn't just create awareness — it closes sales.

And 38.1% say ads *often* influence their buying decisions. Another 47.6% say *sometimes*. Almost no one says never.

AWARENESS VS. PURCHASE

The old model assumed a long gap between seeing an ad and buying. On social, those moments are increasingly the same moment — tap, click, checkout.

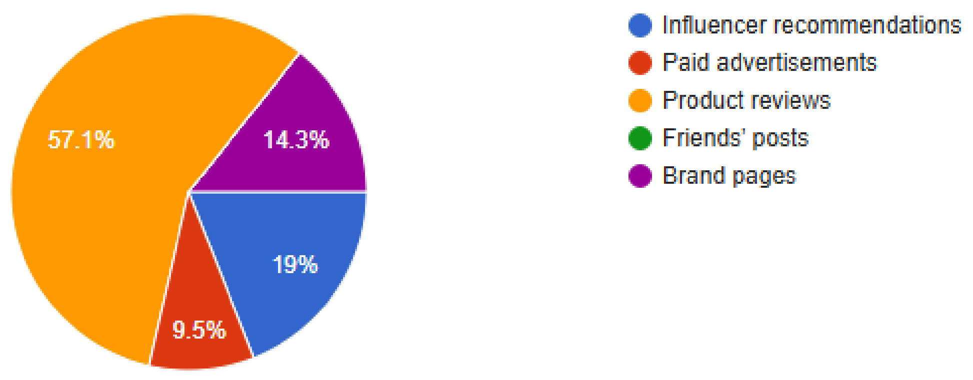
THE IMPLICATION

Social media is now a *full-funnel* channel — top, middle, and bottom — not just a brand-awareness tool.

Reviews beat *everything else.*

When the survey asked which content actually moves a purchase decision, the answer was lopsided.

PRIMARY SURVEY · N=21



57.1%

PRODUCT REVIEWS ARE #1

Influencer recommendations *19%*, brand pages *14.3%*, paid ads *9.5%*. Friends' own posts: *0%*.

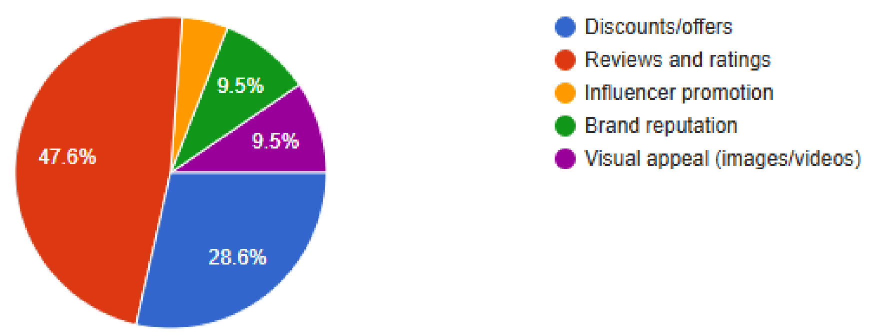
So what. The peer-review economy is real. People weigh what other *customers* said more than what anyone paid — including their own friends, in this sample.

Trust beats *everything else.*

Asked what most encourages an online purchase, respondents ranked the five levers like this:

47.6%	28.6%	9.5%	9.5%	4.8%
REVIEWS & RATINGS	DISCOUNTS & OFFERS	BRAND REPUTATION	VISUAL APPEAL	INFLUENCER PROMOTION
Peer voices outweigh the brand's own voice. People want to see other people who paid.	Urgency works. Limited-time deals collapse the consideration gap.	Helps you make the shortlist. Rarely closes the sale by itself anymore.	Beautiful product shots earn the click. Reviews earn the purchase.	Surprisingly low — influencers create awareness, but reviews close the sale.

PRIMARY SURVEY · N=21



THE STUDENT'S OWN CHART · N=21

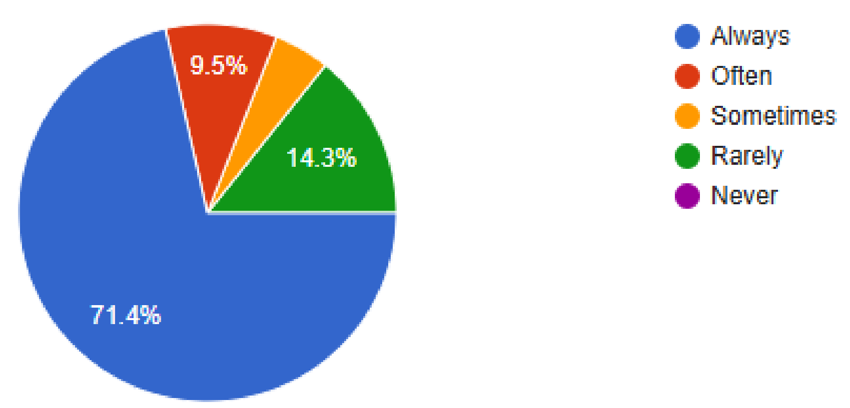
The order matters. Reviews are the gate. A brand can spend everything on visuals and influencers, but if the reviews are thin or bad, the sale stalls.

Reviews + discounts together = *76.2%* of decisions. The rest is rounding.

71.4% *always* check reviews before buying.

Reading reviews isn't a fallback — it's the default step in the buying process.

PRIMARY SURVEY · N=21



71.4%

ALWAYS CHECK REVIEWS

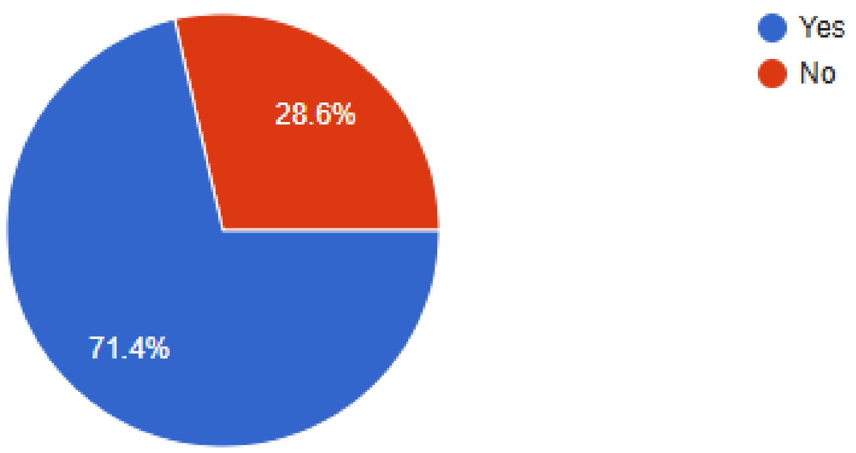
Plus *9.5%* often. Only *14.3%* rarely look — almost no one buys without a peek.

So what. If a brand's reviews are thin, missing, or visibly poor, the sale isn't lost at checkout — it's lost before the buyer even reaches the page.

71.4% have *regretted* a social-media-driven buy.

For all the influence, most buyers also walk away from a purchase feeling burned at some point.

PRIMARY SURVEY · N=21



71.4%

HAVE REGRETTED AT LEAST ONE

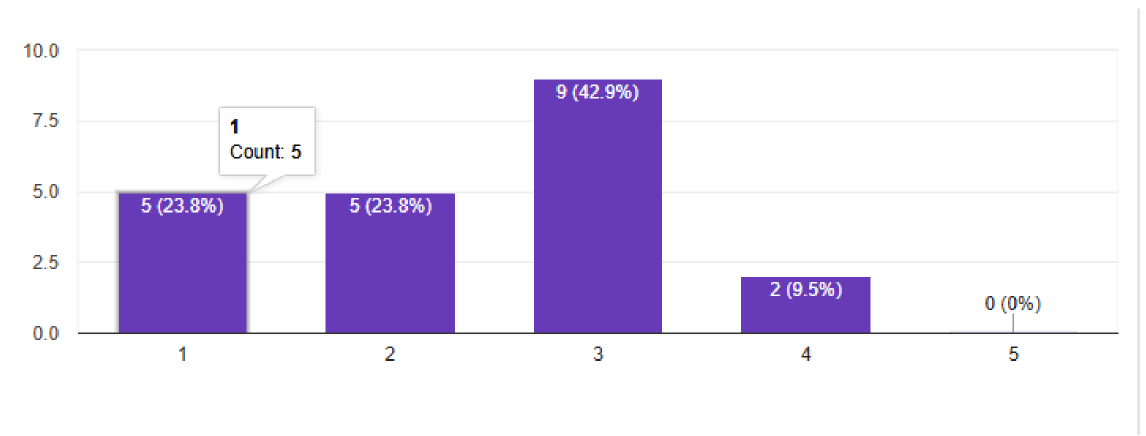
Only *28.6%* say they've never regretted a purchase influenced by social media.

So what. Conversion is real — but it's not always satisfying. This is the side of the funnel marketers don't usually report. It also explains why *reviews* matter so much: buyers know the risk.

Nobody gives them *5 out of 5.*

Asked to rate trust in influencer-promoted products on a 5-point scale, not one respondent picked the top of the scale.

PRIMARY SURVEY · N=21



0%

RATED INFLUENCER TRUST 5/5

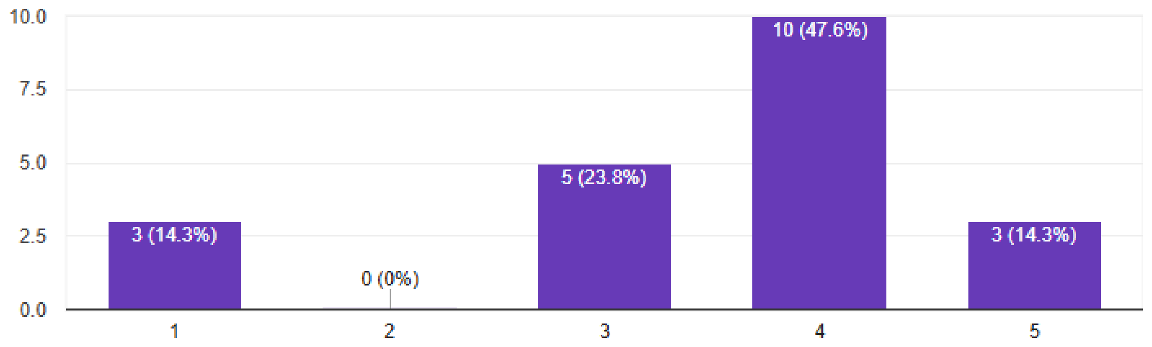
Distribution: *23.8%* at 1, *23.8%* at 2, *42.9%* at 3 (neutral), *9.5%* at 4, *0%* at 5.

So what. Influencers create awareness — not full trust. Reviews do that part. The Nike / DW cases that follow show why the trick is to *borrow* attention from an influencer, then *earn* trust with social proof.

It matters — but not *unconditionally.*

Asked how important social media is to their purchasing decisions on a 5-point scale, the sample landed solidly above neutral.

PRIMARY SURVEY · N=21



62%

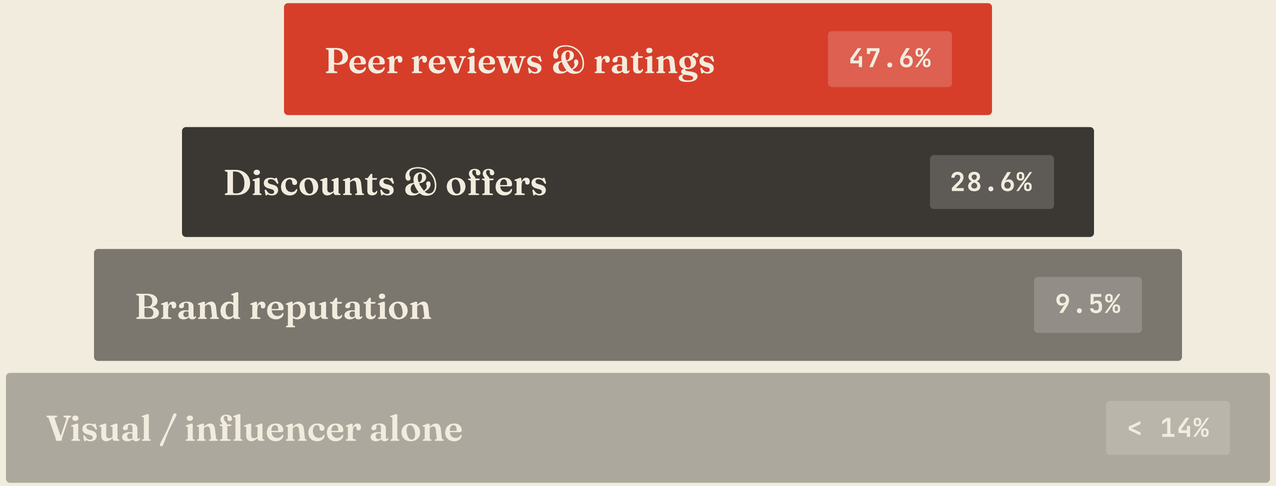
RATE IT 4 OR 5 OUT OF 5

Specifically: *47.6%* at 4, *14.3%* at 5, *23.8%* at 3 (neutral), *14.3%* at 1.

So what. Social media is a serious factor in modern purchasing — the majority say so. But a meaningful *1 in 7* still rate it minimal: this is influence, not gospel.

Who do buyers *actually* trust?

The data ranks information sources by how much weight buyers give them. Smaller = trusted more.



THE RULE

Trust flows *from people, toward brands* — never the other way. Buyers believe other buyers first, then prices, then logos.

WHY IT MATTERS

A perfect ad to a stranger means nothing if three peers say the product is bad. The brand voice is the *last* voice in the chain, not the first.

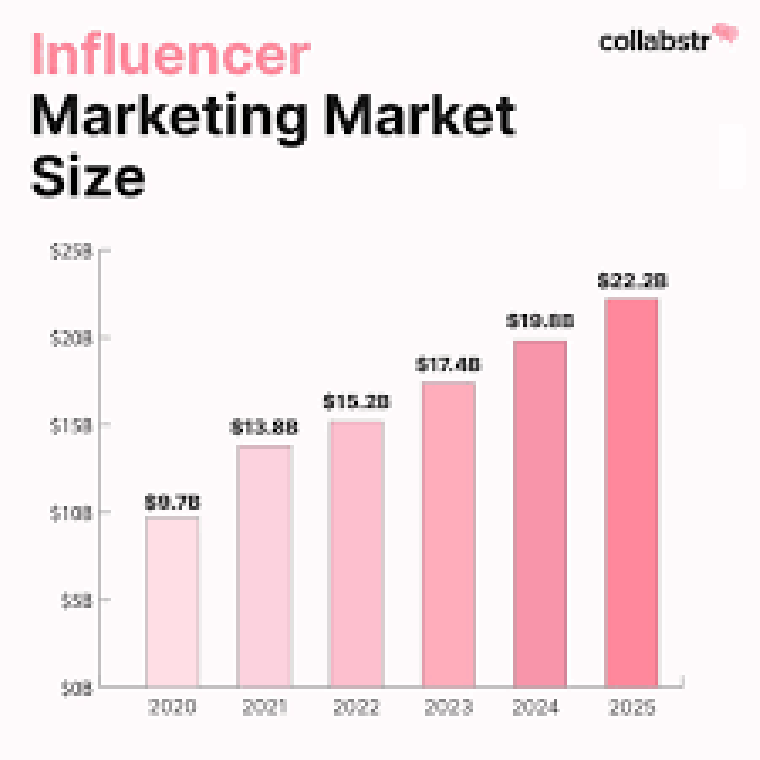
WHAT IT CHANGES

Most of a marketing budget is spent at the bottom of this pyramid. The leverage is at the top: making reviews easier, more visible, and more honest.

A *$22-billion* industry.

What this study is measuring isn't a fringe tactic. Globally, influencer marketing more than doubled in five years.

PRIMARY SURVEY · N=21



*$22.2*B

GLOBAL INFLUENCER MARKETING · 2025

From *$9.7B in 2020* to *$22.2B in 2025* — the channel grew faster than most digital advertising categories in the same window.

So what. When 21 respondents say social media drives their purchases, they're describing the lived end of a market that brands now spend $22 billion a year competing inside.

Starbucks.

The playbook for turning a coffee chain into a *lifestyle* brand on social — built on six recurring tactics.

COFFEE · FOUNDED 1971 · SEATTLE, WA

Sell the *feeling*, not the cup.

Starbucks doesn't lead with the product on social. It leads with the moment — the cup with your name on it, the seasonal red cup, the customer's own post. The brand quietly hosts a stage that customers perform on, and the content writes itself.

SIX RECURRING TACTICS

As documented in the report's Starbucks profile

- 01 Influencer & celebrity collaborations
- 02 Interactive customer engagement campaigns
- 03 User-generated content reposts
- 04 Seasonal product promotions (Red Cup Campaign)
- 05 Personalised digital marketing (name on cup)
- 06 Visually appealing content & storytelling

WHY IT WORKS

Customers do the posting. Starbucks just gives them *something postable*.

Nike.

A masterclass in using influencers to *borrow* trust at scale — verified by a 150-respondent academic study cited in the report.

SPORTSWEAR · GLOBAL

Sell through *people*, not pages.

Nike works with athletes and lifestyle influencers who already have credibility in a niche. The product appears inside a real life the audience already follows. The endorsement doesn't feel like an ad — it feels like a peer's choice.

A 150-respondent academic study referenced in the report found participants exposed to Nike's influencer content reported significantly higher purchase intent than those who weren't. Brand familiarity, trust, image, loyalty and quality all moved together.

THE TAKEAWAY

Buy *access* to a community by partnering with the person it already trusts.

PRIMARY EVIDENCE

@betinapasso · collab with @nikestrength · from the report's primary evidence

FOUR CONTENT THEMES (PER THE CITED STUDY)

01 Product features & specs	02 Lifestyle imagery
03 User testimonials	04 Promotional offers

Daniel Wellington.

A small watch brand outgrew its budget by going *wide*, not big — with two real posts captured in the report.

WATCHES · #DANIELWELLINGTON

Many small voices > one huge one.

DW **gifted** watches — didn't pay — to thousands of micro-influencers (1k–100k followers) instead of paying one megastar. Each creator styled their own photo and posted under #DanielWellington, often with a personal discount code.

The mechanic: zero paid spend up front, hundreds of niche audiences, a personal code to track ROI. Aggregate reach exploded — the brand grew into a **$200M+** business with millions of Instagram followers.

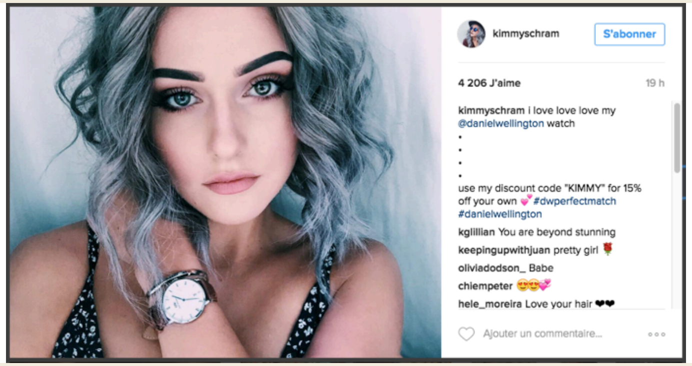
WHY IT WORKED

Many small recommendations from *trusted* voices outperform one giant ad from a stranger — especially when each carries a trackable code.

PRIMARY EVIDENCE

@dhiptadi · #danielwellington · discount code 'dhipt' for 15% off · 2,046 likes

PRIMARY EVIDENCE



@kimmyschram · #danielwellington · discount code 'KIMMY' for 15% off · 4,206 likes

Blue Tokai.

The Indian specialty coffee brand that competed with global giants — six tactics, four observed behaviours, and a real fight on its hands.

COFFEE · FOUNDED 2013 · MATT CHITHARANJAN & NAMRATA ASTHANA

Premium without a *premium* ad budget.

Blue Tokai built its audience around the craft — high-quality roast videos, brewing tutorials, café interiors, customer posts. Instagram became the brand's storefront: young Indian buyers learned what specialty coffee even was from the feed, then went to the café to taste it.

THE SIX TACTICS (PER REPORT)

01 High-quality product photographs & videos	02 Coffee-brewing tutorials & educational content
03 Food-blogger & influencer collaborations	04 Café-culture & lifestyle experiences
05 Engagement via comments, polls, stories	06 Encouraging customer reposts (UGC)

FOUR OBSERVED CUSTOMER BEHAVIOURS

A More likely to try new beverages after seeing them online	B Positive online reviews increased brand trust
C Attracted by premium-quality + modern-lifestyle association	D Social promos drove repeat café visits

THE COMPETITIVE TENSION

Fights for shelf-space-of-mind against **Starbucks** internationally and a wave of local Indian café chains domestically. A bad review online can move a customer to a competitor in one tap.

THE PROOF

A regional brand can *own* a category on social before it ever opens a store in your city.

How a purchase actually happens now.

Five stages. Each stage has a primary lever — get the lever wrong and the customer drops out.

01 / DISCOVER

Scroll the feed

A reel, an ad, a friend's post. Visual and passive — buyer didn't ask for it.

→

02 / TRUST

Check the reviews

Ratings, comments, influencer takes. This is the gate that closes most sales.

→

03 / TRY

Pull the trigger

Usually a small first purchase. Discount or offer often pushes it over the edge.

→

04 / SHARE

Post the result

The buyer becomes the next person's discovery step. Free distribution.

→

05 / LOOP

Repeat & recommend

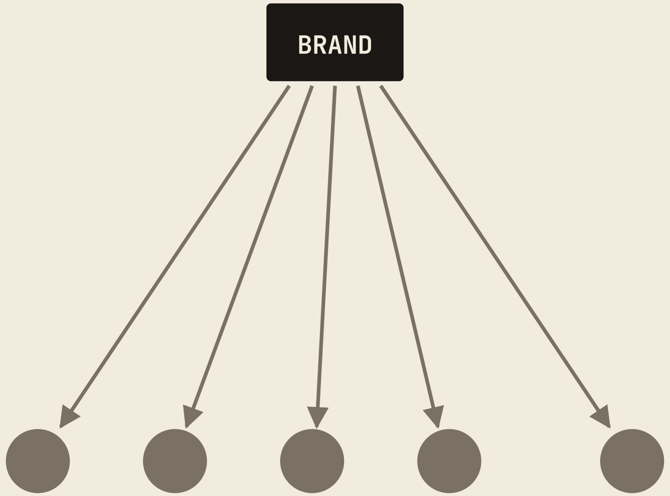
Brand stays in the feed; the customer comes back. Loyalty is now a content loop.

Marketing is now a *conversation.*

The shape of the network changed. The brand used to talk *at* people. Now it talks *with* a community that talks among itself.

THEN — BROADCAST

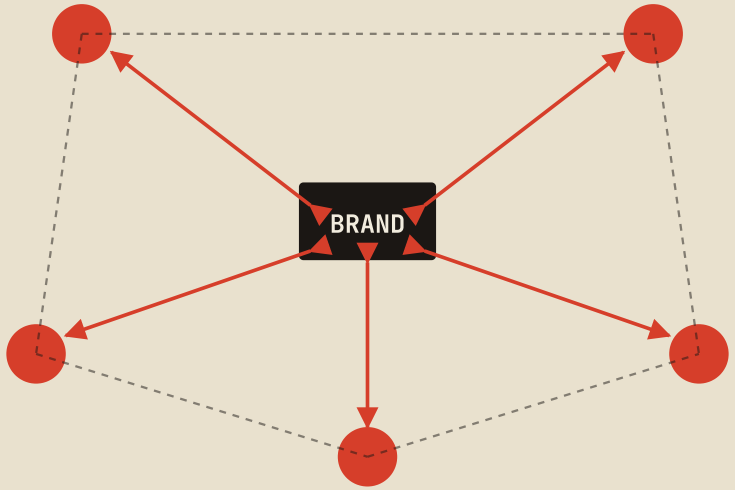
One voice, many ears.



TV, radio, print. The brand spoke. The audience listened. Replies were rare and slow.

NOW — DIALOGUE

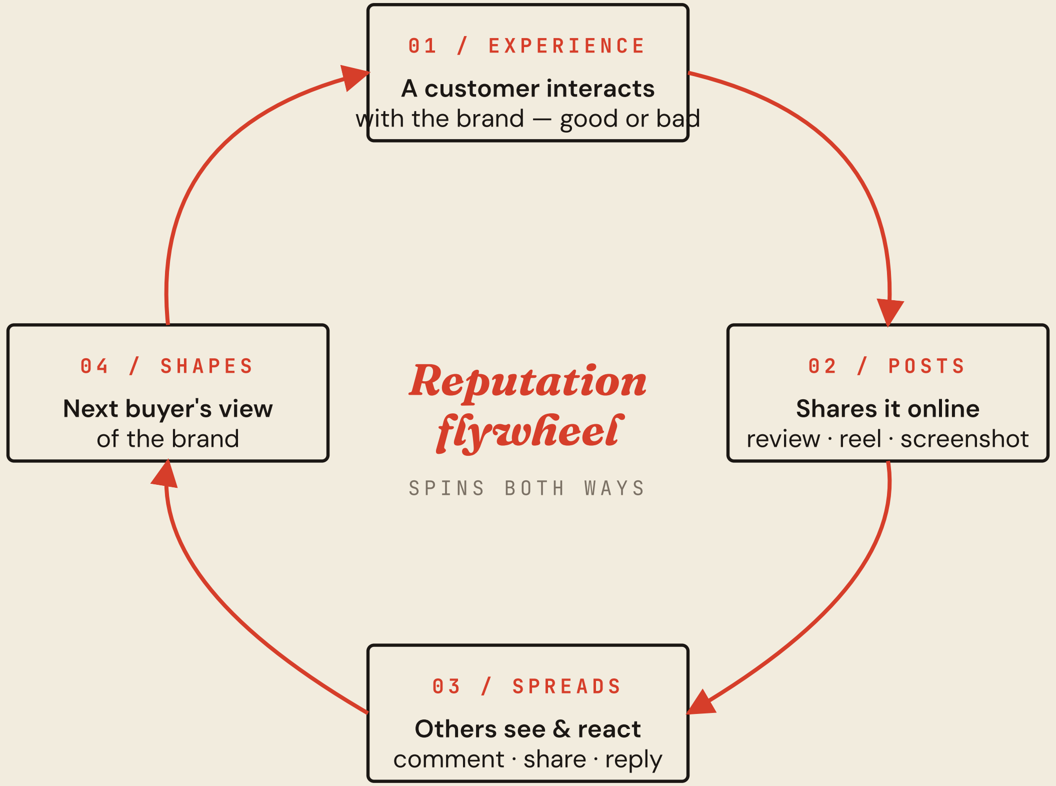
Every voice connects to *every* other.



Comments, DMs, reposts, reviews. Buyers reply to brands — and to *each other*.

The same speed cuts *both ways.*

The mechanism that builds a brand overnight also breaks one. A bad review now travels at the same speed as a good one — sometimes faster.



THE UPSIDE

A good experience becomes *free distribution*. Posts, tags, screenshots turn customers into ad agencies the brand never paid.

THE DOWNSIDE

A bad experience moves *just as fast*. Negative reviews, viral complaints, and screenshots can damage a brand reputation in hours.

WHAT THIS REQUIRES

Active monitoring, fast public replies, real transparency. The brands that win the loop don't try to *silence* it — they participate in it honestly.

Six things the data *actually* said.

01 / Visual platforms dominate. Instagram + YouTube together cover the relevant audience. The rest is rounding error.

02 / Exposure is constant. 85% of respondents see product ads often or always. Discovery is now passive.

03 / Conversion is real. 76% have bought after seeing something on social — not just considered, *bought*.

04 / Reviews are the gate. 47.6% rank them as the #1 factor. Trust beats every other signal.

05 / Discounts unlock action. A close second at 28.6%. Urgency closes the awareness-to-purchase gap.

06 / Young consumers lead. Students and young professionals are the most-influenced and the most-likely to share back.

Eight moves a brand can make tomorrow.

Ranked roughly by leverage — what produces the most change for the least cost.

01 / LEVERAGE

Make reviews unmissable.

It's the #1 factor in 47.6% of decisions. Solicit them, surface them on every page, respond to negatives publicly.

02 / LEVERAGE

Lead with visuals.

Photo › copy. Reel › photo. Invest where the audience already pays attention.

03 / LEVERAGE

Right-size influencers.

Many credible micro-voices outperform one celebrity (the Daniel Wellington playbook).

04 / LEVERAGE

Engineer share-back.

Give people something worth posting — a name on the cup, a custom moment, a hashtag.

05 / TACTIC

Time the offer.

Discounts work — but only with urgency. A limited window converts; a permanent sale erodes price.

06 / TACTIC

Personalise the feed.

Use the platform's targeting. A generic ad to everyone loses to a specific ad to someone.

07 / TACTIC

Reply, don't broadcast.

DMs, comment replies, polls. Two-way communication is the moat.

08 / HYGIENE

Be mobile-first & honest.

Phone-optimised everything. Don't fake reviews or inflate claims — social punishes that fast.

What the data *can't* tell you.

Four categories of constraint. The findings stay useful — within these.

01 / SCOPE

Who we asked.

- 21 respondents — directional, not definitive
- Mostly Ludhiana & North India
- Gen Z & young professionals dominate the sample

02 / METHOD

How we asked.

- Self-report — answers can be aspirational
- Percentage analysis only — no regression or correlation
- No industry-by-industry comparative breakdown

03 / TIME & REACH

When & where.

- A 2026 snapshot — trends shift fast
- Four platforms only — no TikTok, LinkedIn, Pinterest
- Findings age along with the platforms themselves

04 / CONTEXT

What it isolates.

- Measures only the social slice of decisions
- Price, quality, family also drive purchases
- Academic budget — no paid panels or premium tools

READ ACCORDINGLY

A useful study for direction, not for policy. Treat the percentages as a strong signal at this scale — a hypothesis worth testing bigger before any brand bets on it.

CONCLUSION

Social media is the *shelf* now.

The buying decision is made before the wallet opens — in the feed, in the comments, in someone else's video. Brands that win this decade aren't the loudest. They're the ones the audience would post about *without being paid to.*

Where this came from.

Grouped by source type. *Primary* is the survey data; the rest framed it.

22 **Primary survey** — Google Forms · 21 respondents · May 2026 PRIMARY

02 **Mangold & Faulds** (2009). Social media: the new hybrid element — *Business Horizons* ACADEMIC

11 **Harvard Business Review** (2022). Consumer decision-making in the digital age ACADEMIC

19 **Int'l Journal of Research in Marketing** — various studies ACADEMIC

05 **McKinsey & Co.** (2022). The Future of Digital Marketing INDUSTRY

07 **Pew Research Center** (2023). Social media and consumer behavior INDUSTRY

09 **Sprout Social** (2023). Social media engagement insights INDUSTRY

13 **Nielsen** (2022). Trust in advertising INDUSTRY

10 **Forbes** (2023). Impact of influencer marketing on brands TRADE

16 **Social Media Today** (2023). Consumer engagement strategies TRADE

20 **ResearchGate / Academia.edu** — consumer behaviour papers TRADE

01 **Kaplan & Haenlein** (2010). Users of the world, unite! — *Business Horizons* ACADEMIC

03 **De Veirman et al.** (2017). Influencer marketing — *Int'l Journal of Advertising* ACADEMIC

18 **Journal of Marketing Research** — various articles ACADEMIC

04 **Deloitte** (2023). Digital Consumer Trends Report INDUSTRY

06 **Statista** (2024). Social media usage statistics INDUSTRY

08 **HubSpot** (2023). State of Marketing Report INDUSTRY

12 **Google Think Insights** (2023). Consumer behavior trends INDUSTRY

14 **eMarketer** (2023). Social media marketing trends INDUSTRY

15 **Business Insider** (2023). Influencer economy growth TRADE

17 **Adweek** (2022). Digital advertising insights TRADE

21 **Investopedia** — marketing & consumer behaviour concepts TRADE